

Dictatorship and Democracy

In the latter part of the 20th century, Latin American countries veered between nationalist, authoritarian, revolutionary, and civilian regimes. Democracy and some stability have gradually been restored to some nations, but, while the region's economy has improved overall, inequality and poverty remain major challenges.

Chile's military coup, led by General Augusto Pinochet in 1973, was the first of several in 1970s Latin America (see pp.422–23). From 1976, Argentina was ruled by a succession of military figures, including General Leopardo Galtieri, who was among a number of Latin American leaders given training at the School of the Americas, a US army facility in Panama. Both the Pinochet and Galtieri regimes were characterized by the suppression of opposition—thousands of dissidents were tortured or disappeared without a trace.

The corrupt Somoza dynasty, which ruled in Nicaragua from 1936, faced growing opposition in the early 1970s from the International Socialist

Sandinista group FSLN. Sandinista rebels were supported by the Catholic Church and much of the Nicaraguan population. In 1979, Anastasio Somoza was overthrown by popular revolution, and a *junta* (council) of National Reconstruction dominated by the FSLN took over the country.

In 1970s El Salvador, the elitist government of Arturo Molina was resented by a population living in abject poverty. Violence between right-wing paramilitary units known as “death squads” and left-wing revolutionary groups escalated into civil war in 1979. Fearing a communist takeover, the US funded the El Salvadoran military. Fighting and human rights abuses continued throughout the 1980s until

mounting foreign debt, and Argentina slid into recession. The economy finally began to stabilize in 2005.

In the 1980s, General Pinochet's regime in Chile introduced some liberalizing measures as the state moved toward a free-market economy.

DISSIDENT An individual who disagrees, protests, or acts against established opinion, policy, or government.

Greater freedoms of speech led inevitably to calls for democracy, which was restored in 1989. Chile experienced impressive growth in the 1990s and is one of the more robust post-dictatorship economies.

AFTER

In the 21st century, a more politically stable Latin America is increasing its economic ambitions, and many of its leaders are calling for greater regional integration.

MIGRATION NORTH

Poverty in Latin America leads many people to migrate north in **search of a better life** in the US. The US Census shows that migration patterns have shifted radically since World War II, when most immigrants were European. Today the majority of the US's legal migrants are from Latin America, and many more enter illegally. A large proportion of US's estimated 12 million illegal immigrants crossed at the **Mexican border**.

GREATER POLITICAL STABILITY

Despite the problems in the region, in 2006, there were still **democratic elections** in 12 countries of Latin America, including the return of a socialist prime minister in Chile.

BEFORE

Latin America has been shaped by the interests and intervention of foreign powers, first by Europe, and later, the United States.

THE GREAT DEPRESSION

Economic depression in Europe and North America in the 1930s had a **catastrophic effect** on Latin American economies, most of which were **dependent on exports** of raw materials. The plight of the poor in many countries led to a growth of revolutionary movements **<<422–23**.

INDUSTRIALIZATION

During the economic crisis of the 1930s, many governments in Latin America **nationalized resources** previously controlled by **foreign interests**, and began industrialization programs **<<422–23**.

THE COLD WAR

Rivalry between the Soviet Union and US after World War II **<<406–07** even extended to Latin America. The US supported the **Pinochet coup** in Chile, and the overthrow of left-wing regimes, while the Soviet Union backed **communist Cuba**. The 1961 Cuban Missile Crisis intensified this competition. The Soviet Union supported Cuba through an American economic embargo, and the US gave funding and military support to keep their **chosen regimes** in power.



GENERAL PINOCHET

“Sometimes democracy must be bathed in blood.”

GENERAL AUGUSTO PINOCHET, ATTRIBUTED

in 1992, 12 years of violence ended with the El Salvador Peace Accords.

The return of democracy

In the 1980s and 1990s, the political tide turned again in Latin America: dictatorships were overthrown and democracy restored.

Democracy returned to Argentina in 1983. After a period of spiraling inflation, President Carlos Menem introduced wide-ranging reforms in the 1990s, privatizing state assets and imposing a fixed exchange rate. However, Menem and his successor Fernando de la Rúa failed to address

The oil-rich state of Venezuela had regained democratic rule in 1958, but the gap between rich and poor caused discontent. In 1998, President Hugo Chávez (see right) was elected, vowing to bring greater equality. He launched “Plan Bolívar 2000,” which introduced social and welfare reforms and halted the privatization of state assets. Oil profits have helped ensure success for Chávez and growth in the economy.

US intervention

Frequently referred to as “America's backyard,” Latin America has often seen US interference. In 1983 the US invaded the island nation of Grenada after reports that an airport there was secretly intended for Soviet use, and even after the end of the Cold War (see pp.406–07) US troops invaded Panama in 1989, and removed General Noriega's government due in part to alleged drug trafficking.

Some Latin American nations have tried to avoid US economic domination. In 2007, the “Bank of the South” was formed by Hugo Chávez to finance regional infrastructure projects and social programs.



The Mexico–US Border

The order for a fence 700 miles (1,126 km) long to separate the two countries was given by President George W. Bush in 2006 to prevent the flow of illegal immigrants into the United States.

Protests against Pinochet

Chileans take to the streets with pictures of those who went missing during Pinochet's military rule, when more than 3,000 were arrested and murdered by the authorities. In 2001, relatives were finally given access to records and learned the fate of “the disappeared.”

VENEZUELAN PRESIDENT (1954–)

HUGO CHÁVEZ

Elected president of Venezuela in 1998, Hugo Chávez introduced the “Bolivarian Revolution,” a brand of democratic socialism, prioritizing social reform. An admirer of Fidel Castro, he was briefly removed from office in 2002 by the Venezuelan army, but was returned to power by a popular uprising. His radical foreign policy criticizes the US, and calls for improved trade and international aid. However, a 2007 referendum rejected his plans for wholesale constitutional reform.

